Lesson 23: Pronunciation: -S Endings

English Stage 1 (B1) · Unit 2: Getting to Know You

Adapted from Speaking, Listening and Pronunciation Projects for ELLs - Intermediate Level by Brittany Zemlick, Grossmont College (CC BY 4.0): -S Endings.

In this lesson

You will learn the three ways to say the -s ending in English: /s/, /z/ and /ɪz/. You will practice -s endings on plural nouns and on verbs after he, she and it, and link the -s ending to the next word. You will also describe a dream job and read a short text about Andy, the farmer.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Choose the correct -s sound, /s/, /z/ or /ɪz/, for a word.
- Use the final sound of a word (voiced, unvoiced, or hissing and buzzing) to decide the -s sound.
- Add an extra syllable only after hissing and buzzing sounds (watch·es, judg·es).
- Link the -s ending to the next word (works a lot sounds like "work-sa lot").
- Describe what a person does in a job, with the third person -s.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
-s ending	the -s or -es at the end of a plural noun, or of a verb after he, she or it	Did she break one leg or two legs?
third person -s	the -s on a present verb after he, she, it or a name	In her imaginary job, she helps students.
vocal cords	the parts in your throat that move (vibrate) when you make a voiced sound	Where are your vocal cords?
vibration	movement or buzzing	Do you feel vibration or no vibration?
lack of	not enough of something	The student's problem is lack of sleep.
voiced / unvoiced	with vibration / with no vibration	/b/ is voiced; /p/ is unvoiced.
hissing or buzzing sound	/s/, /z/, /ʃ/ as in "push", /ʧ/ as in "watch", /ʤ/ as in "judge"	dress, push, watch, judge
extra syllable	one more beat in the word	watch (1 syllable), watch·es (2 syllables)

Word or phrase	Meaning in simple English	Example
linking	joining the end of one word to the start of the next word	Jen likes poodles. (like-spoodles)
dream job	the job you would most like to have	Brittany's dream job is to be a full-time ESL teacher.

Rules and explanations

Why the -s ending is important

- Sometimes the meaning is not clear without it. "Jen fell off her bike and broke her leg(s)." Did she break one leg or two legs?
- Sometimes the meaning is clear, but the missing -s distracts the listener: "My teacher give two quiz every Friday." (See exercise 2.)

Three sounds for the -s ending

The sound **before** the -s decides the -s sound. Listen to the **sound**, not the spelling.

-s sound	Use it after...	Examples from the book
/s/ as in "looks"	unvoiced final sounds, such as /f/, /k/, /p/, /t/, /θ/ (th)	look - looks, ask - asks, help - helps, wait - waits
/z/ as in "needs"	voiced final sounds, such as /b/, /d/, /g/, /l/, /m/, /n/, /r/, /ð/ (th), /v/, and all vowel sounds	sob - sobs, roam - roams, believe - believes, need - needs, fill - fills, enjoy - enjoys
/ɪz/ as in "watches" (extra syllable)	hissing or buzzing sounds: /s/, /z/, /ʃ/ (sh), /ʧ/ (ch), /ʤ/ (j)	push - pushes, watch - watches, dress - dresses, judge - judges

- The book writes this third sound as /əz/ or /ɪz/. They mean the same thing: an extra syllable that sounds like "iz".
- Only /ɪz/ adds a syllable. "Likes" ends with the letters -es, but it has one syllable and the sound /s/.

Linking -s endings

Native speakers often join the -s ending to the first sound of the next word. This makes your speech sound more natural and helps you understand native speakers.

- **-s + vowel sound:** Andy works a lot. (sounds like "work-sa lot")
- **-s + /s/ sound:** Brittany runs so fast. (sounds like "run-so fast")
- **-s + another consonant:** Jen likes poodles. (sounds like "like-spoodles")

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - Words like "asks", "helps", "wants" and "drinks" end with a group of consonants. Do not add a vowel between them ("as-kis") and do not drop the -s. Keep them one syllable: asks, helps, wants, drinks.

Practice

The audio clips for exercises 9 and 11 are in the folder E:\personal-tutor\materials\library\esl-b1-speaking\attachments\02.07-s-endings\ and on the original web page (link at the end).

1. Warm-up: funny jobs. These strange jobs are real: Ice Cream Taster, Train Pusher, Full-time Netflix Viewer, Professional Cuddler. Match them with the book's pictures: (a) workers pushing people onto a train; (b) a woman eating sorbet; (c) a man watching a TV screen; (d) two people hugging. Write two sentences about what each person does, with the third person -s.

2. Correct the sentence. "My teacher give two quiz every Friday."

3. Before you watch. Where are your vocal cords and why are they important? What are some things that vibrate? "The student's problem is lack of sleep." Is she getting a lot of sleep or very little sleep?

4. Three types of -s endings. Say these words. Which -s sound does each one have? cats, dogs, horses

5. While you watch. Watch the Elemental English video (link below) and answer: a) What are the three ways of saying the plural "s" ending? b) Write the sound of the -s ending in "dogs" and in "cats". c) The change in sound is caused by the sound (before it / after it). d) Give examples of unvoiced sounds, voiced sounds, and sounds that add the extra syllable. e) Why is it important to pronounce the -s ending accurately?

6. Review. Is each sound voiced or unvoiced? /t/, /d/, /s/, /z/

7. Practice: -s endings. Is the last sound /s/, /z/ or /ɪz/?

1. delays 2. weeks 3. fans 4. bridges 5. doves 6. webs 7. bits 8. bags 9. slices 10. backs 11. beds 12. briefs 13. straws 14. blazes 15. jars 16. watches 17. canoes 18. limbs

8. Linking. Draw a link (‿) from the -s ending to the first sound of the next word. Which rule is it: vowel, /s/ sound, or another consonant? Then write the name of a person you know who does each activity (or ask your tutor: "Do you often cook at home?"). Say each sentence with the link.

1. _____ often cooks at home.
2. _____ listens to podcasts.
3. _____ loves working outside.
4. _____ often loses stuff.
5. _____ wants to teach.
6. _____ always eats breakfast.
7. _____ never drinks coffee.
8. _____ avoids eating meat.
9. _____ repairs fences.
10. _____ plays the guitar.

9. Listening: linking -s endings. Play the clip **Listening_Practice_-*Linking*-S_Endings.m4a**. Two words are missing from each statement about Andy. Pause and listen again as many times as you need.

1. Andy _____ _____ farmer. 2. He _____ _____ San Diego. 3. He _____ _____ meat. 4. He _____ _____ outside and taking _____ _____ fresh air. 5. Andy teaches other _____ _____ sustainable agriculture. 6. He _____ _____ teach them how to protect the environment. 7. He often _____ _____. 8. He never _____ _____. 9. He often _____ _____. 10. He _____ _____ podcasts. 11. He _____ _____.

10. More practice. Is the last sound /s/, /z/ or /ɪz/?

1. practices 2. picks 3. offices 4. wants 5. fences 6. goes 7. plays 8. teaches 9. avoids 10. weeds 11. waters 12. repairs 13. hurts 14. listens 15. vegetables 16. works 17. cooks 18. drives 19. pulls 20. podcasts

11. Andy's job. Play the clip **Summary_-_Andy's_job.m4a**. Fill in the missing words (they all end with an "s" sound). Then write /s/, /z/ or /ɪz/ above each word you wrote. Andy is from Oxford, but he _____ in San Diego. ... He also _____, _____ the guitar, and listens to podcasts. ... Every day he _____ outside. He _____ and waters crops. ... and he repairs _____. ... Andy _____ other farmers about sustainable agriculture. He _____ to teach them how to protect the environment.

12. Recording. Listen to the same clip again and practice reading the full text "Andy's Job" (in your lesson material) several times. Record yourself. Did you pronounce every -s ending? Did you link? Record again.

13. Your dream job. Write your dream job title and at least 3 things you do every day. Describe your job to your tutor. Then listen to the tutor's dream job, take notes, and tell it back with he or she and the third person -s.

Speak with your tutor

- "Play a person with a funny job, for example a professional cuddler. I will ask what you do every day, then describe your job with 'he' or 'she'. Correct my -s endings."
- "Say ten plural nouns, one at a time. I will say if the ending is /s/, /z/ or /ɪz/. Tell me if I am right."
- "Ask me 'Do you...?' questions, like 'Do you often cook at home?' Then I will tell you about my family: 'My sister often cooks at home.'"
- "Listen to me read 'Andy's Job'. Tell me which -s endings I missed."

Read aloud

- cats /s/ · dogs /z/ · hor·ses /ɪz/
- looks /s/ · needs /z/ · watch·es /ɪz/
- Andy works a lot. (↘) (work-sa lot)
- Brittany runs so fast. (↘) (run-so fast)
- Jen likes poodles. (↘) (like-spoodles)

- He avoids eating meat. (↘) (avoid-zeating)
- He loves working outside. (↘)
- Andy teaches other farmers about sustainable agriculture. (↘)
- Do you often cook at home? (↗)

Watch online

- Elemental English: -S Endings (three ways to say the -s ending): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=cWNW3-4Wpao
- The Interactive American IPA Chart (to find sound symbols): https://americanipachart.com/
- Learner's dictionary (for the words vocal cords, vibration, lack of): https://learnersdictionary.com/
- The original lesson page, with the audio clips: https://human.libretexts.org/Bookshelves/Languages/English_as_a_Second_Language/Book%3A_Speaking_Listening_and_Pronunciation_Projects_for_ELLs_-_Intermediate_Level_(Zemlick)/02%3A_Getting_to_Know_You/2.07%3A_-S_Endings

Answer key

1. (example answer) a: Train Pusher. A train pusher pushes /ɪz/ people onto the train. He helps /s/ the doors close. b: Ice Cream Taster. An ice cream taster tastes /s/ ice cream. She decides /z/ if a new flavor is good. c: Full-time Netflix Viewer. He watches /ɪz/ shows all day. He writes /s/ about them. d: Professional Cuddler. A professional cuddler hugs /z/ people. She makes /s/ them feel calm.

2. My teacher gives /z/ two quizzes /ɪz/ every Friday.

3. (example answer) My vocal cords are in my throat. They vibrate when I make voiced sounds. A phone vibrates. She is getting very little sleep.

4. cats /s/, dogs /z/, horses /ɪz/

5. a) /s/, /z/, /ɪz/. b) dogs /z/, cats /s/. c) before it. d) Unvoiced: /f/, /k/, /p/, /t/, /θ/. Voiced: /b/, /d/, /g/, /l/, /m/, /n/, /r/, /ð/, /v/ and vowels. Extra syllable: /s/, /z/, /ʃ/, /ʒ/, /ʤ/. e) Without it, the meaning can be unclear (one leg or two legs?), and a missing -s distracts the listener.

6. /t/ unvoiced, /d/ voiced, /s/ unvoiced, /z/ voiced.

7. (book) 1 /z/, 2 /s/, 3 /z/, 4 /ɪz/, 5 /z/, 6 /z/, 7 /s/, 8 /z/, 9 /ɪz/, 10 /s/, 11 /z/, 12 /s/, 13 /z/, 14 /ɪz/, 15 /z/, 16 /ɪz/, 17 /z/, 18 /z/

8. 1 cooks‿at (vowel), 2 listens‿to (consonant), 3 loves‿working (consonant), 4 loses‿stuff (/s/ sound), 5 wants‿to (consonant), 6 eats‿breakfast (consonant; "always‿eats" also links to a vowel), 7 drinks‿coffee (consonant), 8 avoids‿eating (vowel), 9 repairs‿fences (consonant), 10 plays‿the (consonant). The names are your own.

9. (book) 1 is a, 2 lives in, 3 avoids eating, 4 loves working; lots of, 5 farmers about, 6 wants to, 7 loses stuff, 8 gets sad, 9 drinks coffee, 10 listens to, 11 repairs fences.

10. (book) 1 /ɪz/, 2 /s/, 3 /ɪz/, 4 /s/, 5 /ɪz/, 6 /z/, 7 /z/, 8 /ɪz/, 9 /z/, 10 /z/, 11 /z/, 12 /z/, 13 /s/, 14 /z/, 15 /z/, 16 /s/, 17 /s/, 18 /z/, 19 /z/, 20 /s/

11. (book) lives /z/, cooks /s/, plays /z/, works /s/, plants /s/, fences /ɪz/, teaches /ɪz/, wants /s/.

12. Check your own recording.

13. (example answer, from the book) Brittany's dream job is to be a full-time ESL teacher. In her imaginary job she helps students, she attends committee meetings, and she makes materials.

My notes